

B5 The changing role of international organisations: the league and the UN, 1919–c2011

This unit comprises five key topics, each centred on crucial developments in the history of this period. The following themes run through the key topics:

- the organisation and decision making of the League and the UN
- policing conflict – the role of peacekeeping in resolving international conflicts
- the work of the specialised agencies
- the strengths and weaknesses of the organisations
- Great Power involvement in the League (Britain and France) and the UN (US and USSR).

These themes will be the focus of Paper 2, sub-question (c), which will normally draw on the content of two or more topics.

What students need to study:

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| 1 | The creation and successes of the League, 1919–29 | Woodrow Wilson and the setting up of the League. The Covenant of the League of Nations. Membership; Assembly, Council, Secretariat, League agencies and commissions. Successes of the League, including the Åland Islands (1920), Upper Silesia (1921), the Greek-Bulgarian War (1925), Refugee and Drugs Committees. |
| 2 | The League challenged, 1930–39 | The roles of the Great Powers, including the problem of the veto and the failure to curb the dictators. Failures in Manchuria (1931–33), Abyssinia (1935–36). The continuing work of the specialised agencies, including the Child Welfare Committee and the slavery commissions. |
| 3 | Setting up the United Nations Organisation and its work to 1964 | Setting up of the UN and the UN Charter, including structural problems. General Assembly and Security Council, Secretariat, secretary-general, UN peacekeeping forces, Human Rights Commission and UN agencies, the continuing work of the ILO, and the Refugee Organisations; the Mandates Commission and the Disarmament Commission, WHO, FAO, UNESCO and UNICEF. The UN role in Palestine (1947–49), the Korean War (1950–53), and the Congo (1960–64). |
| 4 | The UN challenged, 1967–89 | Case studies in limited success, including the UN role in the Middle East, especially the continuing Palestine problem – Resolutions 242 (1967) and 338 (1973) – and the problem of Lebanon (1975–85). The attempt to resolve disputes in Namibia (1989). The problem of Security decisions – the 'Permanent 5'. The continuing work of the specialised agencies. |

5 The UN at bay, 1990–2011

UN attempts to find long-term peace in identity wars, including Somalia (1991–95), Bosnia (1992–95). The Balkans (1991–99). Mozambique (1990–94) and Sudan (2005–11). The UN role in the Gulf Wars. Obstacles to success. The continuing work of the specialised agencies.
